

STAFF EDITION · TOUR LEADER & TEACHER COMPANION

YPRES 1914–1918

Master Expedition Handbook, On-Site Scripts, Timings & Logistics

TOUR LEADERSHIP DIRECTORATE & OPERATIONAL LOGISTICS

Tour Leaders: Mr Ben Lovett (Head of History) & Mr James Garrett (The History Boys)**Accompanying Staff:** Two Meoncross Staff (Pastoral Care & First Aid Leads)**Expedition Dates:** Thursday 1st – Saturday 3rd October 2026**Base Camp:** Peace Village Hostel, Nieuwkerkestraat 9, 8957 Mesen, Belgium (+32 57 22 60 40)**Transport:** Jet Connect 53-Seat Executive Coach · Driver Rest Regulations strictly observed*The War Memorial at Holy Rood Church, Stubbington — Anchoring our school expedition to our local parish fallen.*

THE TOUR LEADER'S CHARGE: A PILGRIMAGE OF REMEMBRANCE

We lead our pupils not on a detached tour, but on a transformative pilgrimage of memory. By standing at the graves of our Stubbington parish fallen, walking the mud of Passchendaele, and sounding the Last Post at the Menin Gate, we nurture historical empathy, evidential enquiry, and lifelong reverence for the fallen.

"They shall grow not old, as we that are left grow old: Age shall not weary them, nor the years condemn.

At the going down of the sun and in the morning, We will remember them."

TOUR LEADERS:

Mr Ben Lovett & Mr James Garrett

ACCOMPANYING STAFF:

Two Meoncross Staff

SCHOOL BASE 24/7 EMERGENCY:

+44 (0)1329 662182

PEACE VILLAGE BASE CAMP PROTOCOL (MESEN)

Nightly academic debriefs held in Seminar Room A (19:15–20:30). Staff room allocations, emergency first-aid post, and evening student curfew (22:00) managed on-site by accompanying Meoncross staff.

MASTER EXPEDITION TIMETABLE & SALIENT MAP

Tour Leader Pacing, Coach Logistics & Strategic Route

FIELD ROUTE
13 Historic Stops



Strategic Overview of the Ypres Salient (1914–1918): Showing frontlines, allied arcs, canal defenses, and major battle sites.

TOUR LEADER OPERATIONAL SCHEDULE

DAY / TIME	LOCATION & ACTIVITY	TEACHER PACING & KEY DIRECTIVES
Day 1 • 06:15	Depart Meoncross School • Folkestone Le Shuttle	Jet Connect coach departs; collect passports; 11:20 Eurotunnel; arrival in France/Belgium.
Day 1 • 14:30	Stop 1: Essex Farm ADS & Canal Bank	Gather group at Bunker 4; read McCrae; guide pupils to Valentine Strudwick headstone (Plot I.U.8).
Day 1 • 15:15	Stop 2: Langemarck German Cemetery	Transition talk on German bereavement; gather at Kameradengrab; prompt Sorley poem reading.
Day 1 • 16:00	Stop 3: Hooze Crater Museum & Trenches	Mine crater warfare; crater rim observation; front line trench walk; inspect museum collection.
Day 1 • 17:45	Arrive Peace Village Hostel, Mesen	Safety briefing; 18:15 dinner & keys; 19:15 classroom debrief (workbook & 8-mark question).
Day 2 • 09:15	Stop 4: Vancouver Corner (Brooding Soldier)	Canadian stand; gas warfare overview; terrain vantage looking east towards Gravenstafel.
Day 2 • 09:45	Stop 5: Sanctuary Wood (Hill 62) Trenches	Original preserved British frontlines; mud terrain inspection (alternative footwear recommended).
Day 2 • 11:30	Lunch & Snack Shopping (Aldi, Ypres)	Supervised supermarket stop in Ypres; pupils manage budget to buy fresh picnic supplies.
Day 2 • 13:00	Stop 6: Tyne Cot British War Cemetery	Baker/Blomfield pillbox assembly; Binyon reading; direct pupils to Hampshire names on rear wall.
Day 2 • 14:15	Stop 7: Lijssenthoek Military Cemetery	Casualty clearing station evacuation chain; timeline wall; headstone of Staff Nurse Nellie Spindler.
Day 2 • 15:45	Stop 8: Passchendaele Museum (Zonnebeke)	Underground dugout immersion (20ft subterranean bunks & dressing station); Chateau park trenches.
Day 2 • 19:20	Stop 9: The Menin Gate Last Post Ceremony	Arrive early for prime position; brief two Meoncross wreath bearers; Pte. Franklin & Pte. Ayling on Panel 35.
Day 3 • 09:15	Stop 10: Menin Gate Daylight & Ramparts Walk	Daylight panel study without crowds; Ramparts Cemetery walk; read Sassoon's anti-monument poem.
Day 3 • 10:30	Stop 11: De Groote's Chocolatier (Grote Markt)	Supervised confectionery visit; €30–€40 cash envelopes; discuss Ypres stone-by-stone rebirth.
Day 3 • 11:20	Stop 12: Talbot House (Toc H), Poperinge	Tea in soldiers' club; upper room hop-loft chapel; Tubby Clayton's radical egalitarian refuge.
Day 3 • 12:45	Supervised Lunch in Poperinge	Lunch stop in Poperinge town centre before afternoon heritage visits.
Day 3 • 13:30	Stop 13: Poperinge Town Hall Death Cells	Physical visit to cramped cells & execution post; military justice & 2006 statutory pardon.
Day 3 • 14:30	Depart Poperinge • Calais Eurotunnel • Return	Coach departs 14:30 to Calais; 17:50 Le Shuttle crossing; arrival at school approx. 20:00.

STAFF SUPERVISORY PROTOCOL

- Strict headcounts at every coach departure & cemetery gate.
- Accompanying Meoncross staff manage the rear sweep.
- Designated pupil assembly point is the coach bay.
- Pupils must remain in assigned buddy pairs at all times.

DAILY ACADEMIC RHYTHM & FIELDWORK

- Pupils complete Field Companion tasks at each site.
- Evening classroom debrief at Peace Village (19:15–20:30).
- Staff conduct D.I.R.T. marking on the 8-mark enquiry question.
- Flashcard peer recall conducted on the coach journeys.

COACH PACING, PARKING DIRECTIVES & DRIVER HOURS

Our Jet Connect coach driver operates under strict EU tachograph driving hours. Please ensure prompt group boarding 10 minutes prior to scheduled departure times. Designated parking at Ypres is at the Lille Gate coach bays; Poperinge drop-off is near the Grote Markt.

TOUR LEADER TALKING POINTS: THE LOWRY FAMILY OF LEE-ON-THE-SOLENT

Local Connection: William and Annie Lowry of Manor Way Grange, Lee-on-the-Solent, sent all three of their sons to Stubbington House School. All three boys answered the call in 1914, held officer commissions, and all three were killed in action across three different theatres: Gallipoli (William), the Somme (Cyril), and Arras (Eric).

Pedagogical Goal: Connect grand tactical movements to individual boys from our local parish paths. Emphasise that William and Cyril have no known graves, while Eric lies at La Targette near Arras. In grief, William Lowry funded and built the Lowry Memorial Hall in Lee-on-the-Solent to preserve his sons' memory in their home community.



Lieut. William Lowry

8th Gurkha Rifles (Indian Army)

Eldest brother (aged 25); Cambridge graduate. Killed 4 June 1915 leading a frontal charge up Gully Ravine, Gallipoli, under severe Turkish machine-gun enfilade.

Body never recovered from the ravine scrub. Commemorated on Helles Memorial, Turkey.

Helles Memorial, Gallipoli



Lieutenant C. J. P. Lowry

Capt. Cyril Lowry

2nd Bn, West Yorkshire Regt

Youngest brother (aged 20). Served directly under older brother Eric. Killed 25 March 1918 defending Somme crossing at Eterpigny during the German Spring Offensive.

Shot down in full view of Eric; body lost in retreat. Commemorated on Pozières Memorial.

Pozières Memorial, Somme



Captain A. E. E. Lowry

Lt. Col. Eric Lowry

2nd Bn, West Yorkshires (DSO, MC)

Middle brother (aged 25). Decorated war leader (DSO, MC & Bar, French Croix de Guerre). Commanded battalion at Westhoek Ridge and Somme.

Killed 23 September 1918 near Arleux by machine gun inspecting outposts, dying in his runner's arms just 7 weeks before the Armistice.

La Targette British Cemetery (Plot I. C. 2)

LOCAL PARISH CONNECTION: THE LOWRY MEMORIAL HALL & CROFTON TABLET

Devastated by the loss of all three sons, their father William Lowry funded and built the **Lowry Memorial Hall** in Lee-on-the-Solent in 1920 so his boys would never be forgotten. On the marble tablet inside Holy Rood Church, the three brothers' names are inscribed together in Column 2 under the Army roll. Point out to pupils how their physical graves span thousands of miles—from Turkey to the Somme and Arras—yet our parish memorials reunite them forever in our home community.

Staff Action Points at Tyne Cot & In The Field

1. Lead pupils along the central avenue directly to the Cross of Sacrifice built atop the captured German pillbox.
2. Guide students along the rear memorial wall to locate our parish fallen (such as L/Cpl Arthur Newman, Royal Engineers).
3. Emphasise how the tragedy of the three Lowry brothers mirrors the universal bereavement that affected families across every street in Britain.
4. Cross-reference the Stubbington war memorial north beam where their three names appear together before our village square pump.

PEDAGOGICAL DEBRIEF & TARGETED HINGE QUESTION

Hinge Question for Pupils: "How does the loss of three sons from a single local household in Lee-on-the-Solent challenge or reinforce the historical concept of a 'Lost Generation'?"

Workbook Alignment: Ensure pupils record their comparative notes in Section 1 of their Pupil Field Companion before boarding the coach for the afternoon sites.

THE SIX VILLAGE FALLEN & BOY SOLDIERS

Staff Plot Guides & Case Study: Private Valentine Strudwick

STUBBINGTON FALLEN

Holy Rood Parish

The Holy Rood Memorial Roll

SOLDIER	REGIMENT / UNIT	SALIENT LOCATION
Pte. Thomas Franklin	1st Bn, Hampshire Regt	Menin Gate (Panel 35)
Pte. William Ayling	1st Bn, Hampshire Regt	Menin Gate (Panel 35)
Pte. Sydney Muckett	15th Bn, Hampshire Regt	Tyne Cot Memorial (Panel 88-90)
Pte. Arthur Rye	14th Bn, Hampshire Regt	Tyne Cot Memorial (Panel 88-90)
L/Cpl. Archibald Ward	15th Bn, Hampshire Regt	Tyne Cot Memorial (Panel 88-90)
Pte. Charles Warland	3rd/4th Bn, The Queen's	Tyne Cot Memorial (Panel 14-17)



The Memorial Tablet inside Holy Rood Church, Stubbington.

Staff Directive: Distribute local fallen cards to student pairs during coach journey from Boezinge. Each pair will locate their assigned soldier's panel on site.

TOUR LEADER TALKING POINTS: BOY SOLDIER VALENTINE STRUDWICK

Location: Essex Farm Cemetery, Plot I. U. 8 (facing canal bank).

The Story: Enlisted at 14 claiming he was 19; sent to the Western Front with the 8th Rifle Brigade; killed in action by heavy shellfire on 14 January 1916 aged 15 years and 11 months.

Teaching Cue: Ask students to stand around the grave. Compare Valentine's age to their own year group. Note the continuous flow of poppy tributes laid by visiting schools from across Britain.

Mother's Epitaph: "Not Gone From Memory, Not Gone From Love, But Gone To Our Father's Home Above."

Use this epitaph to discuss the profound human cost borne by working-class families who lost adolescent boys before they had ever reached adult life. Contrast this private maternal expression with state-sponsored patriotic slogans.

THE 8TH RIFLE BRIGADE ON THE BOEZINGE CANAL BANK (WINTER 1915-1916)

Valentine served during one of the coldest winters of the war. Standing waist-deep in freezing canal slush, men suffered rampant trench foot and frostbite. On 14 January 1916, a direct hit from an 8-inch high-explosive shell obliterated his section's dugout. Fellow soldiers recovered his remains and buried him at Essex Farm by lantern light.

UNDERAGE ENLISTMENT ENQUIRY & TARGETED HINGE QUESTION

Context: An estimated 250,000 underage British boys enlisted in 1914-1915 due to recruiting sergeant bounties, patriotic fever, and lack of birth certificates.

Hinge Question: "Why did authorities tolerate underage recruitment, and how does standing at Valentine's grave alter our understanding of the volunteer armies of 1914-1915?"

TEACHER FIELD PROTOCOL: MEMORIAL ROLL STUDENT ALLOCATION

Ensure each student pair checks the service numbers, units, and family details of their allocated soldier in their Pupil Field Guide before arriving at Essex Farm and Tyne Cot. Prompt them to locate their soldier's specific panel during personal reflection time.



CWGC Portland Stone Headstone Dimensions: 81cm x 38cm x 7.5cm.
Radical equality across ranks.

TOUR LEADER BRIEFING: HEADSTONE ANATOMY

- 1. Badge:** Regimental heraldry; absolute equality across officer and private.
- 2. Text:** Service number, rank, name, honours, and regiment.
- 3. Cross / Emblem:** Latin Cross, Star of David, or left blank per family wishes.
- 4. Age & Date:** Average age in the Salient was 24.
- 5. Personal Inscription:** Family-paid line (max 66 characters; 3½d per letter). Highlight to pupils how diverse these are: religious, stoic, or heartbroken.

Unknowns: Kipling's phrase: "A Soldier of the Great War — Known Unto God." Over 8,300 lie at Tyne Cot alone.

TOUR LEADER SCRIPT: TOPOGRAPHY OF THE SALIENT

The Ridge: Stand with students looking east from Ypres. The land rises barely 45 metres towards Passchendaele, but in flat Flanders, that low ridge commanded complete artillery domination.

Converging Arcs: German batteries positioned along the arc could shell British rear areas from three directions. Reinforcements had to march into the bulge under continuous observation.

The Flemish Mud: The soil consists of heavy, impermeable clay over sand. Constant shelling destroyed drainage canals, turning the battlefield into a quagmire where thousands drowned.

SIR FABIAN WARE & THE CWGC PRINCIPLES

Founded 1917: **Equality in death** (uniform Portland stone for privates and lords); **permanence** in foreign soil; **no repatriation**. Over 1.7 million commemorated worldwide.

LUTYENS VS BLOMFIELD ARCHITECTURE

Stone of Memory: Lutyens' secular altar ("*Their Name Liveth For Evermore*").

Cross of Sacrifice: Blomfield's Portland stone cross with embedded bronze broadsword.

TOUR LEADER GUIDE: DECIPHERING HAMPSHIRE INSCRIPTION TYPOLOGIES

Prompt pupils to classify family epitaphs on Hampshire Regiment stones into four distinct typologies: (1) **Christian Consolation** ("*Thy Will Be Done*" / "*Sleeping in Peace*"); (2) **Classical Duty** ("*For King and Country*" / "*Dulce et Decorum Est*"); (3) **Raw Maternal Grief** ("*A Day of Memory Sad to Recall, Without Goodbye He Left Us All*"); and (4) **Stoic Resignation** ("*Duty Nobly Done*").

CWGC COMMEMORATIVE ENQUIRY & TARGETED HINGE QUESTION

Hinge Question for Pupils: "Why did the Imperial War Graves Commission strictly forbid wealthy families from erecting private marble crosses, yet permit them to choose and pay for a personal inscription?"

STAFF MANAGEMENT AT CEMETERIES & DECORUM STANDARDS

Remind students that these are active cemeteries visited by grieving relatives and international pilgrims. Walk strictly on grass pathways; no running, shouting, or leaning against headstones. Ensure students conduct pencil rubbings gently with non-abrasive paper.

STOP 1 TOUR SCRIPT: ESSEX FARM ADS

Where We Stand: Concrete bunkers built into the Yser canal embankment. An Advanced Dressing Station where Canadian surgeons triaged thousands during Second Ypres.

Alexis Helmer: On 2 May 1915, McCrae's 22-year-old friend was blown to pieces by an 8-inch shell. McCrae performed the burial by lantern light; next morning he sat on the ambulance step and composed *In Flanders Fields*.

Evacuation Chain: Regimental Aid Post (RAP) Advanced Dressing Station (ADS) Casualty Clearing Station (CCS) Base Hospital.



Concrete dressing station bunkers dug into the canal embankment.

STOP 2 TOUR SCRIPT: YORKSHIRE TRENCH

Discovery: Unearthed in 1992 by amateur archaeologists ("The Diggers") in a modern industrial zone.

What to Notice: The wooden A-frames, fire-bays, deep dugout entrance (holding 200 men), and the high water table requiring constant pump drainage.

Tactical Reality: Trenches here were defensive sandbag breastworks because digging deep struck immediate groundwater.



In Flanders Fields

LT. COL. JOHN MCCRAE (1872–1918) • CANADIAN AMC
• 3 MAY 1915

*In Flanders fields the poppies blow
Between the crosses, row on row,
That mark our place; and in the sky
The larks, still bravely singing, fly
Scarce heard amid the guns below.
We are the Dead. Short days ago
We lived, felt dawn, saw sunset glow,
Loved and were loved, and now we lie,
In Flanders fields.
Take up our quarrel with the foe:
To you from failing hands we throw
The torch; be yours to hold it high.
If ye break faith with us who die
We shall not sleep, though poppies grow
In Flanders fields.*

MCCRAE'S BOTANICAL OBSERVATION & POPPY SYMBOLISM

Explain to pupils why the common field poppy (*Papaver rhoeas*) flourished across the torn fields of Flanders: its seeds lie dormant for decades and only germinate when heavy artillery bombardment churns the lime-rich chalk and clay soil. McCrae observed them blooming amidst fresh graves within days of intense shellfire, transforming a weed into an enduring global symbol.

TEACHER FIELD DIRECTIVES AT ESSEX FARM

Prompt a designated student to read all three stanzas of *In Flanders Fields* standing directly outside Bunker 4. Then lead the group into the cemetery to observe Valentine Strudwick's headstone (Plot I. U. 8). Have pupils examine how close the frontline medical triage was to active artillery fire.

MEDICAL EVACUATION ENQUIRY & TARGETED HINGE QUESTION

Hinge Question: "Why was rapid evacuation to an Advanced Dressing Station the critical factor in preventing gas gangrene and hypovolemic shock on the Western Front?"

Pupil Companion Link: Ensure pupils complete the medical chain diagram on Page 6 of their Field Guide.

STOP 3 TOUR SCRIPT: LANGEMARCK & THE STUDENT MYTH

The Myth of Langemarck: In November 1914, German army communiqués claimed young, enthusiastic student regiments charged into British lines singing *"Deutschland über alles"*. In historical reality, poorly trained schoolboys were cut to ribbons by regular British riflemen delivering rapid "mad minute" volleys.

Kameradengrab (Comrades' Grave): 24,917 soldiers buried in a single mass grave behind the oak gatehouse.

Contrast with CWGC: Dark basalt stone, low flat markers, somber oak canopy—capturing collective sorrow, national mourning, and defeat compared to British radiant Portland stone.

When You See Millions of the Mouthless Dead



CHARLES SORLEY (1895–1915) • CAPT., 7TH SUFFOLKS
• FOUND IN KITBAG

*When you see millions of the mouthless dead
Across your dreams in pale battalions go,
Say not soft things as other men have said,
That you'll remember. For you need not so.
Give them not praise. For, deaf, how should they know
It is not curses heaped on each gashed head?
Nor tears. Their blind eyes see not your tears flow.
Nor honour. It is easy to be dead.
Say only this, "They are dead." Then add thereto,
"Yet many a better one has died before."
Then, scanning all the o'ercrowded mass, should you
Perceive one face that you loved heretofore,
It is a spook. None wears the face you knew.
Great death has made all his for evermore.*

Pedagogical Cue: Emil Krieger Statues

Gather students at the rear boundary facing Emil Krieger's four mourning bronze figures. Note how they huddle together in grief, heads bowed, devoid of martial glory or triumphalism.

Point out the oak trees planted throughout—sacred symbols in German folklore representing national memory, strength, and silent endurance.

Key Comparison: Collective Burial vs Individual Commemoration

THE MYTH OF LANGEMARCK: PROPAGANDA VS MILITARY REALITY

German wartime propaganda mythologized the slaughter of 10,000 university and secondary students as an act of willing heroic patriotism. In post-war Germany, this narrative was seized upon by nationalists to argue that the youth had been betrayed by home-front defeatists ('stab-in-the-back' myth). Contrast this state myth with the bleak, unadorned grief expressed in Krieger's statues.

COMPARATIVE CEMETERY ANALYSIS & TARGETED HINGE QUESTION

Hinge Question: "How does the deliberate gloom, dark granite, and mass grave architecture of Langemarck produce a fundamentally different emotional impact than the open lawns and white Portland stone of CWGC sites?"

Staff Observation: Ask pupils to contrast the individual CWGC headstones at Essex Farm with the flat basalt slabs at Langemarck, each inscribed with up to 20 names.

LOGISTICAL TRANSFER TO PEACE VILLAGE HOSTEL (MESEN)

Depart Langemarck at 17:15. Coach journey south across the Salient to Peace Village Hostel in Mesen takes approx. 35 mins. On arrival: room keys, baggage drop, 18:15 evening meal, followed by 19:15 evening debrief session.

DAY 2 FIELD STUDY • GAS WARFARE & UNDERGROUND MINES

Stops 4 & 5 • Vancouver Corner & Hooge Crater • Tour Scripts

MENIN ROAD
Gas & Mine Warfare

STOP 4 TOUR SCRIPT: VANCOUVER CORNER

22 April 1915: The first lethal use of poison gas in history. 168 tons of chlorine released by German forces against French Algerian troops.

The Canadian Stand: Canadian troops held the 4-mile gap by urinating on handkerchiefs to neutralise chlorine. Commemorated by Chapman Clemesha's 33ft *Brooding Soldier* monument.

Tactical Terrain: Direct students' gaze towards Gravenstafel ridge to demonstrate how gas flowed downhill along natural folds in the ground.

STOP 5 TOUR SCRIPT: HOOGE CRATER

Underground War: Tunnelling companies dug deep into blue Flemish clay to detonate ammonal charges beneath German trenches.

The Hooge Crater: Detonated on 19 July 1915 (1,700lb ammonal), creating a 120ft wide crater. First German flamethrower attack occurred here 11 days later against the 8th Rifle Brigade.

Museum Collection: Superb collection of trench weapons, body armour, and periscopes.

Break of Day in the Trenches

ISAAC ROSENBERG (1890–1918) • PRIVATE, KING'S OWN



*The darkness crumbles away.
It is the same old druid Time as ever,
Only a live thing leaps on my hand,
A queer, sardonic rat,
As I pull the parapet's poppy
To stick behind my ear.
Droll rat, they would shoot you if they knew
Your cosmopolitan sympathies.
Now you have touched this English hand
You will do the same to a German
Soon, no doubt, if it be your pleasure
To cross the sleeping green between.
What do you see in our eyes
At the shrieking iron and flame
Hurled through still heavens?*



Hooge Crater site: Preserved mine craters and trench warfare lines.

STOP 5 MUSEUM FOCUS: THE 8TH RIFLE BRIGADE FLAMETHROWER ATTACK (30 JULY 1915)

Guide pupils through the museum's preserved flamethrower artifacts. On 30 July 1915, German forces unleashed portable *Flammenwerfer* jetting burning oil 30 yards into British trenches here, catching the 8th Rifle Brigade completely unprepared. Explain how defensive psychology changed when fire and chemical agents were introduced as frontline weapons.

TECHNOLOGY & WARFARE ENQUIRY • TARGETED HINGE QUESTION

Hinge Question: "How did the simultaneous introduction of industrial weapons—chlorine gas, flamethrowers, and deep subterranean mines—completely shatter pre-war conceptions of heroic soldiering?"

Field Directives: Have pupils walk the restored trench line behind Hooge Crater Museum and inspect the lip of the mine crater.

SUPERVISED FIELD LUNCH & BOARDING DIRECTIVES

Eat packed picnic lunches at Hooge Crater Museum picnic area. Restroom break and museum shop visit. Prompt boarding at 12:45 for transfer to Tyne Cot Commonwealth Cemetery.

STOP 6 TOUR SCRIPT: THE SCALE OF TYNE COT

The Scale: Largest Commonwealth war cemetery in the world. 11,961 burials, of which 8,369 are unidentified ('Known Unto God').

Herbert Baker's Architecture: Baker preserved three German concrete machine-gun pillboxes inside the cemetery. He deliberately mounted Sir Reginald Blomfield's Great Cross of Sacrifice directly atop the central bunker, leaving an observation slit open to reveal the concrete beneath.

The Memorial Wall: Semicircular stone wall listing 34,984 soldiers missing in action after 16 August 1917.



Cross of Sacrifice standing atop captured German pillbox.

For the Fallen

LAURENCE BINYON (1869–1943) • BRITISH MUSEUM • 1914



*With proud thanksgiving, a mother for her children,
England mourns for her dead across the sea...
They went with songs to the battle, they were young,
Straight of limb, true of eye, steady and aglow.
They shall grow not old, as we that are left grow old:
Age shall not weary them, nor the years condemn.
At the going down of the sun and in the morning
We will remember them.
They mingle not with their laughing comrades again;
They sit no more at familiar tables of home;
They have no lot in our labour of the day-time;
They sleep beyond England's foam.*

Staff Coordination: Parish Fallen

Following the recitation of Binyon's *For the Fallen* at the Cross of Sacrifice, lead pupils along the rear Memorial Wall to locate our parish fallen (including L/Cpl Arthur Newman, Royal Engineers). Lay the Meoncross remembrance cross.

Allow 25 mins personal reflective walk across the rows.

SITING THE CROSS OF SACRIFICE ATOP THE GERMAN BUNKER

King George V visited Tyne Cot during construction in 1922 and suggested preserving the central German bunker. Sir Herbert Baker enclosed it within the base of Blomfield's Great Cross of Sacrifice, leaving an observation slit visible at ground level. Emphasise to pupils how British architects literally erected Christian sacrifice atop the concrete machinery of war.

PASSCHENDAELE TACTICAL ENQUIRY & TARGETED HINGE QUESTION

Hinge Question: "Why did Field Marshal Haig persist with the Passchendaele offensive for three months when rain and artillery fire had reduced the low ridge to an impassable swamp?"

Teacher Guidance: Prompt pupils to look back down the slope towards Ypres to appreciate the commanding view German machine-gunners possessed over every approach.

NEXT STOPS: LIJSSENTHOEK & PASSCHENDAELE MUSEUM

Board coach at 14:00 sharp. Drive to Lijssenthoek Military Cemetery (Stop 7) to study the Casualty Clearing Station evacuation chain and Nurse Nellie Spindler, followed by Passchendaele 1917 Museum (Stop 8).

STOP 9 TOUR SCRIPT: THE MENIN GATE

54,395 Names: Inscribed with Commonwealth soldiers missing in the Salient prior to 16 August 1917. Designed by Sir Reginald Blomfield as a classical triumphal arch.

The Last Post Ceremony: Sounded every night at 20:00 by volunteer fire brigade buglers without fail since 1928 (suspended only during WWII occupation).

Thomas Franklin & William Ayling: Guide students to Panel 35 to locate Private Thomas Franklin and Private William Ayling of the 1st Battalion, Hampshire Regiment.



The Menin Gate Memorial: Inaugurated July 1927.

On Passing the New Menin Gate

SIEGFRIED SASSOON (1886–1967) • CAPT., ROYAL WELCH FUSILIERS



*Who will remember, passing through this Gate,
The unheroic Dead who fed the guns?
Who shall absolve the foulness of their fate,—
Those doomed, conscripted, unvictorious ones?
Crudely renewed, the Salient holds its dead,
And magnificent, the arch of triumph stands;
Sure are the streets, untorn by shot and shell;
Here was the world's worst wound. And here with pride
Their names are graven whom the world forgot,
Well might the Dead who struggled in the slime
Rise and deride this sepulchre of crime.*

Staff Wreath-Laying Protocol

19:20: Secure prime standing position on northern walkway under the arch.

19:45: Designated Meoncross pupil wreath bearers escorted by Mr Lovett to ceremonial marshalling area.

20:00: Buglers sound Last Post; two-minute silence; official wreath laying.

Staff Lead: Mr Ben Lovett & Mr James Garrett

THE LAST POST ASSOCIATION & THE CIVIC BUGLERS

Explain to pupils the extraordinary history of the ceremony: founded in 1928 by local Ypres police commissioner Pierre Vandenbraambussche to honour British soldiers who defended the town. Except for the period of German occupation from May 1940 to September 1944 (when it was sounded instead at Brookwood in England), the volunteer buglers of the Ypres Fire Brigade have sounded the call every night at 20:00 without fail.

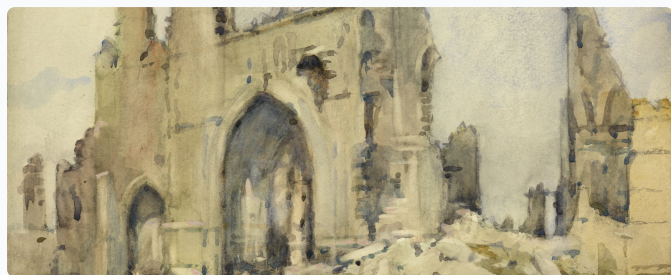
SASSOON'S ANTI-MONUMENT CRITIQUE & TARGETED HINGE QUESTION

Hinge Question: "Why was Siegfried Sassoon so repulsed by Blomfield's triumphal arch, calling it a 'sepulchre of crime', while grieving families found immense comfort in seeing their sons' names carved in stone?"

Teaching Tip: Have pupils read Sassoon's poem privately while standing under the cavernous vaulted archway before the ceremony begins.

EVENING RETURN TO PEACE VILLAGE & NIGHT PROTOCOL

Depart Menin Gate at 20:45. Arrive hostel 21:15. Evening drinks, cookies, and reflective briefing. Curfew and phone collection in corridor at 22:00 sharp. Staff overnight watch roster active.



The Cloth Hall, Ypres (1919): Watercolour by Scottish war artist **Emily Murray Paterson RSW (1855–1934)**, painted on-site amidst the ruins after the Armistice (Imperial War Museum collection).

STOP 10 TOUR SCRIPT: THE REBIRTH OF YPRES

Total Destruction: By 1918, Ypres was rubble; Winston Churchill wanted the ruins left untouched as a British national monument. Instead, Belgian citizens rebuilt stone-for-stone.

The Lakenhalle: Built in 1304; meticulously reconstructed over 40 years.

De Groote's Chocolatier: Supervised visit for pupils to experience modern Flemish civic life and chocolate heritage (€30–€40 cash envelopes).



Talbot House Façade, Poperinge: Opened in December 1915 by Rev. Philip 'Tubby' Clayton as an unranked sanctuary for all soldiers behind the lines.

STOP 12 TOUR SCRIPT: TALBOT HOUSE (TOC H)

The Haven Behind the Lines: Army Chaplain Tubby Clayton opened this house in Poperinge as an alternative to pubs and brothels.

"All rank abandon ye who enter here": Officers and privates drank tea from identical mugs, played the piano, and conversed as human equals.

The Upper Room: Climb the creaking stairs to the hop-loft chapel. A carpenter's bench served as the altar.

The Soldier

RUPERT BROOKE (1887–1915) • SUB-LIEUTENANT, ROYAL NAVAL DIVISION

*If I should die, think only this of me:
That there's some corner of a foreign field
That is for ever England. There shall be
In that rich earth a richer dust concealed;
A dust whom England bore, shaped, made aware,
Gave, once, her flowers to love, her ways to roam;
A body of England's, breathing English air,
Washed by the rivers, blest by suns of home.
And think, this heart, all evil shed away,
A pulse in the eternal mind, no less
Gives somewhere back the thoughts by England given;
Her sights and sounds; dreams happy as her day;
And laughter, learnt of friends; and gentleness,
In hearts at peace, under an English heaven.*



TALBOT HOUSE: THE UPPER ROOM HOP-LOFT CHAPEL

Take pupils in small groups up the steep attic staircase to the 'Upper Room'. Clayton converted the hops drying loft into a quiet haven of prayer, using an old carpenter's bench as the altar and candlelight. Men carved their names and regimental numbers into the wooden posts before returning to the trenches.

STOP 13 BRIEFING: POPERINGE TOWN HALL DEATH CELLS & SHOT AT DAWN

Context: Physical visit to the cramped brick holding cells and wooden execution post in the Town Hall courtyard.

Teaching Narrative: Discuss the harshness of military discipline, the medical misunderstanding of shell shock (neurasthenia), and the 2006 statutory pardon granted to 306 British and Commonwealth soldiers executed at dawn.

Hinge Question: "How does the radical egalitarian compassion of Talbot House contrast with the cold military discipline of the Poperinge Death Cells just 200 yards away?"

Trench & Military Terminology

ADS	Advanced Dressing Station: Frontline medical bunker behind trenches for urgent triage before casualty evacuation.
A-Frames	A-shaped timber frames supporting duckboard walkways above waterlogged trench mud.
Pillbox	Reinforced concrete machine gun bunker built by German forces to withstand heavy artillery shellfire.
Salient	A bulge in military lines surrounded by the enemy on three sides, exposed to converging artillery arcs.
Sump	A deep drainage pit dug beneath trench duckboards to catch pooling rainwater.
Trench Foot	Severe fungal and circulatory condition caused by prolonged immersion in cold, wet mud.
Enfilade	Gunfire directed along the length of a trench line rather than frontally across no-man's-land.
Duckboards	Slatted timber walkways laid over trench floors to keep troops out of stagnant clay mud.
Traverse	U-shaped bends built into trenches every few yards to contain shell blasts and stop enfilade fire.

CWGC & Memorial Terminology

CWGC	Commonwealth War Graves Commission: Founded 1917 by Fabian Ware to care for 1.7 million fallen.
Cross of Sacrifice	Designed by Sir Reginald Blomfield: Portland stone cross bearing an embedded bronze broadsword.
Stone of Memory	Designed by Sir Edwin Lutyens: altar-like stone carved with Kipling's phrase <i>"Their Name Liveth For Evermore"</i> .
Kameradengrab	German 'Comrades' Grave': a central mass burial holding thousands of fallen soldiers (e.g. 24,917 at Langemarck).
Portland Stone	Fine white limestone from Dorset, chosen for its luminosity and radical equality across all military ranks.
Special Memorial	Headstone carved with <i>"Believed to be buried in this cemetery"</i> where exact grave plot was lost.
Screen Wall	Memorial wall listing names of casualties whose individual headstones cannot be erected.
Memorial to Missing	Monuments dedicated to dead soldiers with no known grave (e.g., Menin Gate, Tyne Cot, Ploegsteert).
Orientation Table	Carved bronze or stone dial indicating bearings and distances to distant frontline objectives.

USEFUL FLEMISH & FRENCH TOPONYMS IN THE SALIENT

Ieper: Flemish name for Ypres.

Poperinge: Town behind lines known affectionately to British troops as *"Pop"*.

Heuvelland: 'Hill Country' south of Ypres (home of our Peace Village Hostel base in Mesen).

Lakenhalle: The medieval Cloth Hall in the Grote Markt of Ypres.

Menenpoort: Flemish for the Menin Gate.

TOUR LEADER EQUIPMENT CHECKLIST & ON-SITE KIT

- **School First Aid Kits:** Carried by accompanying Meoncross staff at all times (including travel sickness meds).
- **Pupil Medication Roster:** Asthma inhalers & EpiPens inspected prior to coach boarding.
- **Emergency Whistle & Hi-Vis Vests:** Worn by staff leads during urban transit in Ypres and Poperinge.
- **Meoncross Poppy Wreaths:** Safely stowed in coach forward locker for the Menin Gate ceremony.

CODE OF CONDUCT & EXPEDITION STANDARDS

1. **Quiet Respect:** Cemeteries are active places of mourning. Walk strictly on grass paths; do not sit on headstones or climb on memorial panels.
2. **Mobile Phone Protocol:** Phones may be used for photographs during the day. Collected each evening in dedicated staff bags at curfew.
3. **Hostel Downtime:** Quiet hours from 22:00 in Peace Village corridors. Respect international guests and staff sleep cycles.
4. **The Mission:** Always remember that we represent Meoncross School and our village parish of Holy Rood before the people of Belgium.